The Kid Nobody Could Handle

By Kurt Vonnegut

INTRODUCTION

Author Jodi Picoult wrote: Sometimes, all it takes to become human again is someone who can see you that way, no matter how you present on the surface . . .

The Kid Nobody Could Handle by Kurt Vonnegut

NARRATOR: **(Pg 270-283)** It was 7:30 in the morning. Inside a restaurant a very kind fat man with a headful of music looked down at the jiggling yolks of his breakfast eggs. George M. Helmholtz was director of the band of Lincoln High School and life had treated him well. Each year he dreamed the same big dream. He dreamed of leading as fine a band as there was on the face of the earth. And each year the dream came true. Youngsters played their hearts out for him.

Bert Quinn, the restaurant owner sat down in the booth with the bandmaster. He was a bachelor, a small, dark, humorless man. A fifteen-year-old boy with tough, stringy muscles standing out on his neck and forearms

4NG Fanatics

was mopping the aisle between booths. Childhood lingered in his features, but when he paused to rest, his fingers went hopefully to the beginnings of a mustache. He mopped like a robot, jerkily, brainlessly, but took pains not to splash suds over the toes of his black boots.

HELMHOLTZ: *(taking a sip of coffee; to Quinn)* That boy, I've seen him around school.

QUINN: *(laughing cheerlessly)* Billy the Kid? The storm trooper? *(calling to the boy)* Hey, Jim! Come here a minute.

NARRATOR: The boy's eyes were as expressionless as oysters.

QUINN: This is my brother-in-law's kid by another marriage. His name's Jim Donnini; he's from the south side of Chicago, and he's very tough.

NARRATOR: Jim Donnini's hands tightened on the mop handle.

HELMHOLTZ: How do you do? You want a lift to school, Jim?

QUINN: Yeah, he wants a lift to school. *(to Jim)* Go on, kid, wash up and shave.

NARRATOR: Robotlike, Jim marched away.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

HELMHOLTZ: Where are his parents?

QUINN: His mother's dead. His old man married my sister, walked out on her, and stuck her with him. The court didn't like the way she was raising him and put him in foster homes for a while. Then they decided to get him out of Chicago, so they stuck ***me*** with him. *(shaking his head)* Those boots, the black jacket -- and he won't talk. Won't study. Can't even read and write very good.

HELMHOLTZ: Does he like music? Or drawing? Does he collect anything?

QUINN: He likes to polish those boots. *(smiles ruefully)* He ***had*** a collection. Took it away from him and threw it in the river.

HELMHOLTZ: Threw it in the river?

QUINN: Yeah. Eight knives -- some with blades as long as your hand.

NARRATOR: Helmholtz paled. A prickling sensation spread over the back of his neck.

HELMHOLTZ: Oh, this is a new problem at Lincoln High. I hardly know what to think about it. It's a kind of sickness, isn't it?

4NG Fanatics

QUINN: *(grimly)* No more talk about the poor little sick boy. That's all he's heard from the social workers and the juvenile court. From now on, I'll ride his tail till he straightens up or winds up in the can for life.

****** in Helmholtz's car on the way to school*******

HELMHOLTZ: *(brightly)*Like listening to music? *(no response)* Ever drum with your fingers or keep time with your feet? *(Jim sighs heavily)* Or whistle? If you do any of those things, it's like picking up the keys to a whole new world -- a world as beautiful as any world can be. *(Jim gives a soft Bronx cheer)* There! The glorious voice of the brass wind instruments! Starts with a buzz on the lips. *(happily does his own Bronx cheer)*

NARRATOR: The seat springs creaked as Jim shifted his weight to get a cigarette from inside his leather jacket.

HELMHOLTZ: *(Softly)* Sometimes, I get so lonely, I don't see how I can stand it. I feel like doing all kinds of crazy things, just for the heck of it -- things that might even be bad for me. *(Jim blows a smoke ring)* And then! *(snaps his fingers)* I remember I've got one tiny corner of the universe I can make just the way I want it! I can go to it until I'm happy again.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

JIM: Aren't you the lucky one? *(yawns)*

HELMHOLTZ: I am. My corner of the universe happens to my band -- Music. Mr. Beeler, in zoology, has his butterflies. Mr. Trottman, in physics, has his pendulum and tuning forks. Making sure everybody has a corner like that is about the biggest job we teachers have. I . . .

NARRATOR: The car door opened and slammed, and Jim was gone. *(beat)*

********At school********

NARRATOR: Helmholtz's first class of the morning was C Band, where beginners wheezed and tooted as best they could. Helmholtz stepped onto the podium. There was a note calling him to a special faculty meeting about vandalism. Someone had broken in and wrecked the office of Mr. Crane, head of the English Department. The poor man's treasured books, diplomas, and the beginnings of eleven novels had been ripped, crumpled and drenched with ink. Helmholtz was sickened. He couldn't believe it.

It didn't become real to him until late that night, in a dream. Helmholtz saw a boy with barracuda teeth, with claws like baling hooks. The monster climbed into a

4NG Fanatics

window and dropped to the floor of the band rehearsal room. It clawed to shreds the biggest drum in the state. Helmholtz woke up at two in the morning. There was nothing to do but dress and go to the school.

Helmholtz rolled the drum back and forth on its cart; he turned the lights on and off, on and off. The drum was unharmed. The band's treasure house was safe. With the contentment of a miser counting his money, Helmholtz began to polish the sousaphones. [It was then that] he heard a noise in the chemistry laboratory next door. He sneaked into the hall, jerked open the laboratory door, and flashed on the lights. Jim Donnini had a bottle in either hand -- splashing acid over the periodic table of elements and the blackboards covered with formulas. The scene was the most repulsive thing Helmholtz could have looked upon.

HELMHOLTZ: *(voice shaking with anger)* Get out.

JIM: *(smiling with bravado)* What're you gonna do? You gonna call the cops?

HELMHOLTZ: *(grabbing a rag and wiping up acid)* Clean up. Save what I can. If I'd caught you hurting the bass drum, I think I would have killed you. But I wouldn't have had

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

any intelligent thoughts about what you were -- what you thought you were doing.

NARRATOR: He [felt] helpless. He had a bag of tricks for making boys behave like men -- tricks that played on boyish fears and dreams and loves. But here was a boy without fear, without dreams, without love.

JIM: It's about time this place got set on its ear! What good is it?

HELMHOLTZ: *(sincerely)* It's the best thing human beings ever managed to do. If you smashed up all the schools, we wouldn't have any hope left.

JIM: *(bitterly)* What hope?

HELMHOLTZ: The hope that everybody will be glad he's alive. Even you.

JIM: That's a laugh.

HELMHOLTZ: *(with growing anger)* Isn't there anything you care about? Anything? Anything but those boots?

NARRATOR: He marched Jim into his tiny office, opened a locker and took a trumpet from it. He thrust it into Jim's arms.

HELMHOLTZ: There! *(full of emotion)* There's my treasure -- the dearest thing I own. Smash it! I won't stop you.

4NG Fanatics

Watch my heart break while you do it. Go on! *(Jim doesn't move)*

NARRATOR: Helmholtz grabbed Jim's belt and dumped him on the floor. He pulled Jim's boots off and threw them into a corner; jerked the boy to his feet again and thrust the trumpet into his arms. Jim Donnini was barefoot now. He had lost his socks with his boots. The feet, once big black clubs were narrow as chicken wings now -- bony and blue.

The boy shivered, then quaked. Each quake seemed to shake something loose inside, until, at last, there was no boy left, no boy at all.

HELMHOLTZ: *(overwhelmed with remorse, reaches out to Jim)* Jim! Jim -- You know what's special about the trumpet? *(Jim stops quaking)* It belonged to John Philip Sousa! I'll trade it to you, for your boots. I don't think they're good for you. You can learn to play it.

NARRATOR: Helmholtz released Jim slowly, sure the boy would topple. Jim didn't fall. He stood alone, the trumpet still in his arms. *(beat)* Helmholtz drove Jim home and let him out at Quinn's restaurant. The soft pats of Jim's bare feet echoed down the empty street.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

He climbed through a window and into his bedroom behind the kitchen. All was still.

The next morning Helmholtz sat in a booth again. Quinn joined him. Jim mopped, eyes down, refusing to notice Helmholtz. And he didn't seem to care when a surf of suds broke over the toes of his small and brown Oxfords.

QUINN: *(jerking his head at Jim)* Kid! Go get Mr. Helmholtz his horn. *(to Helmholtz)* You take away his boots and give him a horn, and I'm not supposed to ask questions? I'm not supposed to find out you caught him taking the school apart? *(with disgust)* It's over. I'm sending him back where he came from.

HELMHOLTZ: *(weakly)* To another string of foster homes? That will be the end of him. He can't stand to be thrown away like that one more time.

QUINN: I can't help him; I can't hurt him. Nobody can. There isn't a nerve in him.

HELMHOLTZ: *(sadly)*A bundle of scar tissue.

NARRATOR: The bundle of scar tissue returned with the trumpet. Impassively, he laid it on the table in front of Helmholtz.

4NG Fanatics

HELMHOLTZ: *(with a forced smile)* It's yours, Jim. I gave it to you.

QUINN: Take it, Helmholtz. All he'll do is swap it for a knife or a pack of cigarettes.

HELMHOLTZ: He doesn't know what it is . . . ***yet***. It's hope.

NARRATOR: After a long silence, Helmholtz picked up the trumpet. He had thought that his greatest treasure, the trumpet, could buy a soul for Jim. The trumpet was worthless. Deliberately, Helmholtz hammered the trumpet against the table edge and handed the wreck to Quinn.

QUINN: Ya busted it. Why'dja do that? What's that prove?"

HELMHOLTZ: *(fighting back tears and shame)* Life is no damn good.

NARRATOR: Helmholtz, the mountain that walked like a man, was falling apart. Jim Donnini's eyes filled with pity and alarm. They came alive. They became human. Helmholtz had got a message through. Quinn looked at Jim, and something like hope flickered for the first time in his bitterly lonely old face.

********* Two weeks later*********

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

NARRATOR: Two weeks later, a new semester began at Lincoln High. In the band rehearsal room, the members of C Band were waiting for their leader . . . Helmholtz stepped onto the podium and rattled his baton against his music stand. He glanced at Jim Donnini, who sat in the last seat of the worst trumpet section of the worst band in school. ***His*** trumpet, ***John Philip Sousa's*** trumpet, had been repaired.

HELMHOLTZ: Think of it this way. Our aim is to make the world more beautiful than it was when we came into it. It can be done. You can do it.

NARRATOR: A small cry of despair came from Jim Donnini.

JIM: How?

NARRATOR: It was meant to be private, but . . .

HELMHOLTZ: Love yourself and make your instrument sing about it . . . *(with his baton)* A-one, a-two, a-three.

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kurt Vonnegut
Book: Welcome to the Monkey House, Pgs 270-283
ISBN: 978-0385333504
Publisher: Dial Press
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2006

AWARD HISTORY

ND State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY